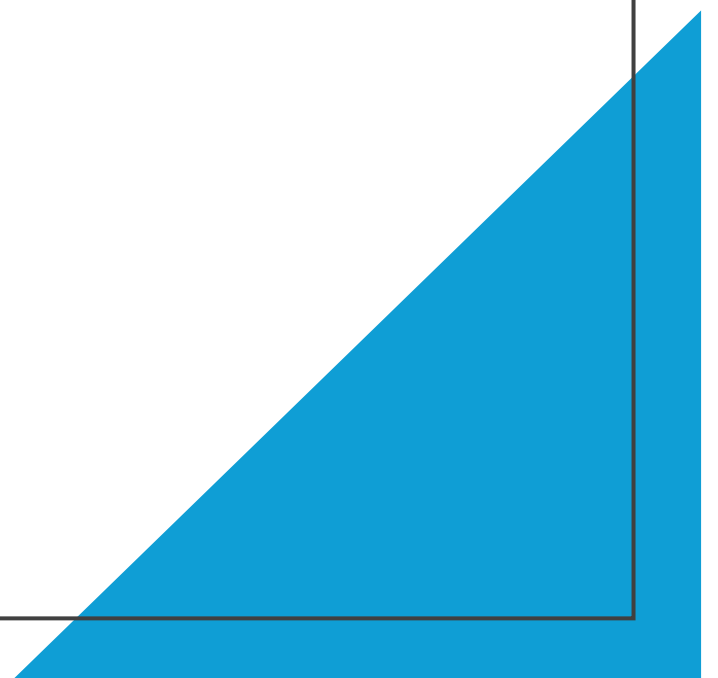


UN approves 40-member scientific panel on the impact of artificial intelligence over US objections

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CMET-6000 Roberto Cecilio



WORLD NEWS

UN approves 40-member scientific panel on the impact of artificial intelligence over US objections



UN Secretary General António Guterres is welcomed by Britain's Prime Minister Keir Starmer to 10 Downing Street, London, Friday, Jan. 16, 2026. (Henry Nicholls/Pool Photo via AP)

BY [EDITH M. LEDERER](#)

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Main Findings

- The **United Nations General Assembly approved a 40-member global scientific panel** focused on studying the *impacts and risks of artificial intelligence* — a first of its kind at the U.N. level.
- **The vote was overwhelming (117-2)** with only the United States and Paraguay voting *no*, and a few abstentions.
- U.N. Secretary-General **Antonio Guterres called the panel's creation a “foundational step”** toward developing a shared scientific understanding of AI that all countries — regardless of technology level — can use.
- The panel's members are experts from diverse regions and disciplines, with the intention of producing *balanced, independent insights into AI's societal, economic, and ethical effects*.
- U.S. officials objected, calling the panel an “overreach” of the U.N.'s mandate and expressing concern about international bodies influencing how AI is governed.

Broader Implications for Society

AI's Global Reach & Regulation

- The establishment of this scientific panel signals that **AI governance and scientific evaluation has become a *global policy priority***, not just a national or corporate concern.
- Efforts to understand AI's impacts extend beyond economic competition and innovation — they touch on *equity between nations, ethical use of technology, and global risk mitigation*.

Balancing Innovation with Safety

- The U.N. initiative reflects broader debates about *how to balance rapid AI advancement with careful oversight*, public welfare, security, and fairness between developed and developing countries.
- Countries disagree on how governance should work: some see international scientific bodies as essential, while others worry about loss of technological leadership or external control.

Relevance and Potential Influence on the Construction Industry

AI Adoption in Construction

- AI technologies (e.g., predictive planning, robotics, safety monitoring, design optimization) are already transforming construction workflows.
- Recommendations from a globally respected scientific panel may influence *best practices, safety standards, and regulatory expectations* for AI systems, including those used in construction technology.

Risk & Governance Frameworks

- As AI becomes more embedded in construction — for project management, automation, risk assessment, etc. — *global norms or guidelines* shaped by this panel could inform what is considered responsible or safe AI use in infrastructure and building projects.

Potential Standards and Collaboration

- The panel could contribute to *standards that improve interoperability, reliability, and oversight* of AI tools that firms in construction adopt, which may benefit multinational construction firms or suppliers operating across jurisdictions.